

New XPS laptops

Dell has launched three new notebooks and has decided to concentrate on Alienware, Inspiron and XPS series and do away with the Adamo line

Tenders floated for \$35 laptop

The Ministry of Human Resource Development has floated a tender for the cheapest laptop / tablet that is expected to come out

Cover Feature

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with an investment of ₹1,500 crore, which may bring down prices further.

Videocon is also a contract manufacturer for a lot of companies. Philips has entered a 5-year deal with Videocon, and the latter will manufacture, market and distribute Philips TVs in the country. The point we are trying to make here is, this gives Videocon the edge over other LCD TV companies, who generally source panels from abroad, and do most of the assembling abroad as well. With a manufacturing unit in India, combined with Videocon's robust distribution network, we should see an increase of its market share.

There are other players like Moser-Baer and Godrej for instance, who offer LCD TVs at economical prices. However, based on our test results, we can tell you that they have a long way to go before they can pose a serious threat to Sony or Samsung. Offerings like 3D or something innovative like gesture gaming which was seen in Godrej's Game LCD TV look nice, but this is a time when consumers in general and first time buyers' in particular are more interested in better quality for the money they spend.

LAPTOPS / NETBOOKS

Laptops is one product category that is seeing increasing differentiation by the day. With netbooks added to the fray, this market has become very diverse. Here again we foresee a lot of challengers. But first up let's look at some numbers to get an overall picture of who stands where.

As far as sales go, 8.05 lakh units were sold between April and June 2010. This is a staggering 61 per cent growth over the same period last year. The undisputed leader here is Dell, with a market share of 29.2 per cent, followed by HP and Acer.

Netbook sales have also grown at an

unprecedented rate globally and India is no exception to the rule. According to Gartner, first quarter sales of laptops grew by around 43 per cent. Although HP and Dell are leaders as far as laptops are concerned, ASUS registered a staggering growth of 113 per cent as compared to just 23.2 per cent growth for HP, and 33.1 per cent for Dell.

Just like its desktop counterparts, laptops now cater to different target users based on their usage scenarios. For example, there are laptops aimed at everyday users, business users, gamers, multimedia junkies, users who are always on the go, etc. So even though we have the leaders defined – HP, Dell and Acer – we think we can stick our necks out and try to predict challengers in each of the aforementioned segments.

Netbooks

No matter what the statistics say, there is only one clear challenger in this category – ASUS. With its EeePC brand of netbooks, and an exhaustive portfolio teamed with competitive pricing, we feel that it will take a lot for the leaders to dismantle ASUS from this market. ASUS has a whopping 16 models in this segment alone, with some interesting innovations – their touchscreen netbooks (EeePC T91MT, 3G netbook, etc.), for example, are certainly making waves. MSI's Wind series of netbooks is the only other competitively priced range with a wide product portfolio, and desirable qualities such as HD readiness, chiclet keyboards, etc.

Gaming laptops

Here MSI has around 15 products on offer for the gaming community with specifications to cover all types of gamers. ASUS on the other hand has only two offerings in this space, but its G51Jx laptop is a 3D gaming laptop, a unique offering separating it from the rest. Gaming forums and circles are buzzing about HP and Dell working on its own line of 3D laptops.



A high end 3D gaming laptop - ASUS G51Jx

Dell's Alienware series of laptops are the only competitors here with their insane configurations and innovative designing of the M series laptops.

Multimedia laptops

ASUS NX90Jq completely blew us away because of its unconventional design featuring an 18.4-inch screen with two vertical tower speakers, something that has not been seen on any laptop before. Apple is another brand to look at, as far as this category of laptops go. Now with the introduction of Intel Core i series of laptops in the Indian market, it is a definite challenger to HP's Envy series of laptops.

Regular and business laptops

The only way ASUS and MSI can compete with the leaders is on the pricing front, but Acer also has very competitive pricing. It's hard to see ASUS and MSI truly challenging the leaders here.

After scanning through some forums, we realised that users are willing to spend extra money on a branded laptop which offers better after-sales service. HP and Dell are way ahead of others as far as the number of service centres go. HP's India web site has an exhaustive list of service centres. This is one area where brands like ASUS and MSI need to play catch up. 

Laptop sales grew by around 43 per cent in India in the first quarter, of which growth in Netbook sales rose by a whopping 71 per cent in the same period